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**Redeeming Creation as a Steward: The Deployed
Talent, the Buried Gift, and the End of the Useless
Class**

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Abstract

Paper 1 grounded a seven-problem set in the doctrine of creation; Paper 2 argued that the Fall confirms rather than abolishes that set, intensifying it through the covenantal cascade of Romans 5 and Romans 8, and located the structural pivot of the series in the protoevangelium of Genesis 3:15 — the promise of a coming seed who reverses what the first man lost. The present paper takes up the redemption stage of that promise as it bears on the human steward's *work*. Its claim is narrow and load-bearing: redemption does not abolish the steward's vocation but restores and commands it. The redeemed image-bearer is not released from the creative-and-governing office

but reinstated in it, and is *commanded to deploy* the gifts entrusted to him. The paper reads the Parable of the Talents (Matt 25:14–30) as the canonical case: the servants who invest and multiply what they are given are commended; the one who *buries* his talent — out of fear and a distorted view of the master — is named “wicked and slothful” and cast out. The contemporary frame the paper answers is the post-work thesis in its most candid form — that automation will retire human labor and produce, in Yuval Noah Harari’s phrase, a “useless class” whose dignity must be secured by consumption rather than contribution, and whose wisest course is managed idleness. Against that program the paper argues that the prospective abdication of the human creative-and-governing office to the machine, accompanied by a turn to idleness, is the modern form of the buried talent — and that its root, as in the parable, is a wrong view of who the Master is. The argument is made by grace and not by works-righteousness: deployed work is the *fruit* of redemption (Eph 2:8–10), not its price. Throughout, the paper carries the series’ seven-problem spine and names the depth the redemption stage adds to each, featuring the vocation problem (#4), and lands its case on the framework thread the series has carried from the first paper: in the age of autonomous systems the human is not the candidate for replacement but the governing-and-curating status set over autonomy, and the steward is *commanded to govern*, not licensed to abdicate.

§1. The Question and the World’s Claim

The previous paper ended at the pivot: the seed of the woman is promised at the very moment the curse is pronounced, and the long redemptive history that follows is the tracing of that promise toward the one in whom it is fulfilled. The full Christological treatment of that fulfillment is reserved for a later paper in this series. The present paper takes up a prior and more immediately practical question, the one the redemption of the steward raises for the steward’s *work*: if the human creative-and-governing office was conferred at creation (Paper 1), cursed and inverted at the Fall (Paper 2), and is now, in the redemptive economy the protoevangelium opened, being restored — then what does the restored office *require* of the one who holds it? Is the redeemed steward released from the

labor of creation and governance, freed at last into rest from the cursed toil? Or is he reinstated in the office and commanded to exercise it?

The question is not abstract. It arrives in a culture that has begun, with increasing candor, to answer it in the first sense — to propose that the human relation to work is on the verge of a terminal transformation, and that the wise and humane response is to prepare for a future in which most human beings do not work at all. This is the post-work thesis, and in its most serious forms it is not a utopian daydream but a sober extrapolation from observable trends in automation. It deserves to be stated at full strength before it is answered.

The thesis has an economic premise and an anthropological conclusion. The economic premise is that the present wave of automation differs in kind from prior waves: where earlier mechanization displaced particular tasks and the displaced labor migrated to new sectors, machine learning and robotics are now climbing the ladder of cognitive and manual work fast enough, and broadly enough, that there may be no higher rung left for the displaced to climb. Erik Brynjolfsson and Andrew McAfee develop this case with care in *The Second Machine Age*, arguing that digital technologies are decoupling productivity from employment and that the distributional consequences — not the aggregate ones — are the crisis.¹ John Maynard Keynes anticipated the structure of the argument nearly a century ago in “Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren,” coining “technological unemployment” and predicting a future in which the economic problem is solved and humanity’s real difficulty becomes how to occupy a leisure it is not equipped to bear.² The economic premise, in its contemporary form, is contestable in its timing but serious in its structure, and the paper does not propose to dispute it on economic grounds.

The anthropological conclusion is where the thesis becomes a rival account of the human. Yuval Noah Harari states it with the candor that makes him, again, the most useful single interlocutor: the

¹Erik Brynjolfsson and Andrew McAfee, *The Second Machine Age: Work, Progress, and Prosperity in a Time of Brilliant Technologies* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2014). The decoupling-of-productivity-from-employment argument and the distributional framing are developed across the book’s central chapters.

²John Maynard Keynes, “Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren” (1930), in *Essays in Persuasion* (London: Macmillan, 1931). Keynes coins “technological unemployment” and frames the long-run problem as the human capacity to use leisure well.

coming century, he argues, may produce not merely unemployment but *unemployability* — a “useless class” of human beings for whom the economy has no productive role at all, whose problem is not exploitation but irrelevance.³ The humane response, on this account, is to decouple dignity and income from work — through a universal basic income, through engineered leisure, through the provision of meaning by consumption, entertainment, and pharmacology rather than by contribution. The proposal has a left-utopian wing that welcomes the prospect: Aaron Bastani’s *Fully Automated Luxury Communism* and the wider post-work literature of Nick Srnicek and Alex Williams read the automation of labor as emancipation — the long-awaited release of humanity from the curse of work into a realm of freedom.⁴ It has a more anguished wing — David Graeber’s account of the proliferation of meaningless “bullshit jobs” registers, against the utopians, that human beings deprived of genuinely useful work do not flourish in their leisure but suffer a distinct spiritual misery, even when paid.⁵ And it has a policy wing — Andrew Yang’s *The War on Normal People* takes the displacement as given and argues for a basic income as the only humane management of an inevitable uselessness.⁶

Across these wings the structural claim is constant, and it is the claim this paper must answer: that human work is, at bottom, *the production of economic value*; that machines are coming to produce that value better than humans can; and that the human future therefore lies not in work but in its absence — in a managed idleness underwritten by the machine’s productivity. The claim is the vocation problem (Paper 1’s Problem #4) in its mature register. If our defining activity is the production of value, and the machine produces value better, then human work is not redirected but *retired*, and the wise response is to learn, at last, how to do nothing.

³Yuval Noah Harari, *Homo Deus: A Brief History of Tomorrow* (New York: Harper, 2017), where the “useless class” is coined in the treatment of the future of work; and Harari, *21 Lessons for the 21st Century* (New York: Spiegel & Grau, 2018), ch. 2 (“Work”), where the thesis is developed at length.

⁴Aaron Bastani, *Fully Automated Luxury Communism: A Manifesto* (London: Verso, 2019); Nick Srnicek and Alex Williams, *Inventing the Future: Postcapitalism and a World Without Work* (London: Verso, 2015). Both read the automation of labor as emancipation toward a post-work realm of freedom.

⁵David Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs: A Theory* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2018). Graeber’s argument that meaningless employment produces a distinct spiritual suffering is the anguished counter-wing within the post-work literature.

⁶Andrew Yang, *The War on Normal People: The Truth About America’s Disappearing Jobs and Why Universal Basic Income Is Our Future* (New York: Hachette, 2018).

This is the position the paper must answer. It will not be answered by pretending the automation is not real.

The displacement premise has been quantified and defended at book length since. Carl Frey and Michael Osborne's much-cited estimate that a large share of existing jobs is susceptible to computerization, and Daniel Susskind's sustained argument that this wave is different in kind and points toward a genuine, lasting contraction of human labor, give the thesis its strongest empirical form.⁷ The paper does not contest the economics; it contests the anthropology the economics is made to carry.

§2. *The Secular Theory, Stated Fairly*

It is owed to the post-work thesis to follow it past its premise to the genuine goods it pursues, because the thesis is not, in its serious forms, an apology for sloth. It is, in its own self-understanding, a liberation movement.

The good it pursues is release from *toil*. The post-work theorist looks at the history of human labor — the broken backs, the dangerous trades, the dignity ground down in repetitive and meaningless tasks, the lives consumed by work that served no one's flourishing including the worker's — and sees in automation the possibility of release. This is not a frivolous hope; it is, in its structure, continuous with the long human longing for rest, and the Christian tradition is in no position to sneer at it. Scripture itself names work, after the Fall, as cursed with thorns and sweat (Gen 3:17–19), and names rest as a divine gift built into the creational order (Gen 2:2–3). The post-work theorist who longs for the end of toil is longing for something real, and the longing is not, in itself, the error.

The good it pursues is also the *decoupling of dignity from economic performance*. Here the post-work thesis converges, strikingly, with a claim this series has made from its first page. Graeber's

⁷Carl Benedikt Frey and Michael A. Osborne, "The Future of Employment: How Susceptible Are Jobs to Computerisation?" *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* 114 (2017): 254–280; and Daniel Susskind, *A World Without Work: Technology, Automation, and How We Should Respond* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2020). The empirical case that the present automation wave threatens a lasting contraction of human labor.

account of “bullshit jobs” is in one register a secular protest against precisely the capability-as-worth premise Paper 1 dismantled: he observes that a society which grounds dignity in productive contribution will manufacture pointless contribution rather than confront the possibility that dignity might not be grounded in contribution at all.⁸ Yang’s case for a basic income is, in its motivating intuition, an attempt to secure the worth of persons whom the economy has declared worthless — to insist that the human being whose labor the market no longer wants is not thereby a lesser human being.⁹ The intuition is correct. The series has argued it at length: worth is conferred, not earned; the un-productive human is not a lesser human; dignity does not grade by output. On the bare claim that human dignity must not be allowed to track economic usefulness, the post-work theorist and the steward agree.

The divergence is over what follows. The post-work theorist infers from “dignity is not grounded in work” that *work may therefore be dispensed with* — that if our worth does not depend on our labor, then the removal of our labor is no loss to our worth, and the humane future is one in which the machine works and the human rests. The inference is the error, and it is worth stating precisely, because it is not obviously wrong. It has the form: *work is not the ground of human worth; therefore work is not constitutive of human vocation*. The first clause is true. The second does not follow from it. And the whole of the present paper is, in one sense, the demonstration that it does not follow — that work can fail to be the *ground* of worth while remaining, all the same, a *command* laid on the worth-bearer; that the steward’s dignity is conferred and not earned, *and* that the steward is nonetheless commissioned to deploy what he has been given.

A word of method, owed here as it was in the previous paper. The paper will draw, at §4, a pointed identification between the modern turn to managed idleness and the buried talent of the parable. That identification is *structural*, not a charge of conscious wickedness against any particular advocate of a basic income or a shorter work week. The parable diagnoses a posture of the heart — fear

⁸Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs*. The observation that a contribution-grounded dignity will manufacture pointless contribution rather than relinquish the premise is Graeber’s, repurposed here as a secular witness against capability-as-worth.

⁹Yang, *The War on Normal People*. The motivating intuition — that the human whose labor the market no longer wants is not a lesser human — is granted as correct; the inference to provisioned idleness is contested.

of the master, a distorted view of who he is, and the withdrawal of the gift from circulation that follows — and the paper's claim is that the post-work program, taken to its anthropological conclusion, instantiates that posture at the scale of a civilization, whatever the intentions of its individual advocates. The distinction between the structural identification and the personal charge is held in force from here forward.

It is worth adding what the post-work thesis tends to forget about its own ideal. Josef Pieper argued that genuine *leisure* is not idleness or amusement but a contemplative receptivity — the basis of culture, worship, and the highest human activity — so that a future of mere release-from-labor, filled with consumption, is not the leisure the tradition prized but its counterfeit.¹⁰ The thesis promises leisure and delivers idleness, and the two are not the same.

§3. *Common Ground and the Point of Divergence*

The cleavage, as in the previous paper, is at the level of what a human being *is*, and it can be located precisely.

Both the post-work theorist and the steward agree that human worth is not constituted by economic productivity. They part over whether human *flourishing* is constituted by the exercise of the creative-and-governing faculties — over whether the human is the kind of creature for whom the deployment of skill, agency, and creativity is a need to be met or a burden to be relieved. The post-work thesis, in its emancipatory form, treats the exercise of productive faculty as a burden: the less of it required, the freer the human. The steward reading treats the exercise of the creative-and-governing faculty as a constitutive dimension of the image: a human who exercises it is doing what an image-bearer is *for*, and a human prevented from or relieved of it altogether is not liberated but diminished.

This is the grounding problem (Problem #1) in the register the redemption stage gives it. Paper 1 grounded worth in conferred status against the capability account; the present stage must add a distinction the first paper did not need to draw, because the post-work thesis exploits precisely the

¹⁰Josef Pieper, *Leisure: The Basis of Culture*, trans. Alexander Dru (New York: Pantheon, 1952; German orig. 1948). Genuine leisure as contemplative receptivity, distinct from idleness or amusement.

gap between the two claims it conflates. *Worth* is conferred and unconditional — this the series holds without qualification. *Flourishing*, however, is not indifferent to activity. The image-bearer's worth does not depend on his deploying his gifts; his flourishing — his living as the kind of creature he was made to be — does. The post-work thesis, having rightly seen that worth is not earned, wrongly concludes that activity is therefore optional to the human good. The steward reading holds both: the worth is conferred and the activity is commanded, and the command is not a tax on the worth but the form the worth's flourishing takes.

The divergence, then, is not over whether the machine can produce economic value better than the human. Grant that it can — grant the strongest form of the economic premise. The divergence is over whether the human creative-and-governing faculty was given for the production of economic value in the first place, such that its economic obsolescence would be its retirement. The series has argued from the beginning that it was not: the cultivate-and-keep mandate of Gen 2:15 is doxological and relational before it is economic, an exercise of the image toward the glory of God and the good of the neighbor, and its economic dimension is a consequence and not the essence. If that is right, then the automation of the economic dimension does not retire the faculty; it *relocates* its exercise — exactly the move this series has named, from the first paper, with the framework thread: the human moves up, from competing with the machine at production to governing the machine's production, and the creative-and-governing office is not abolished by automation but, if anything, made more urgent by it.

This is the cleavage. *Same protest against capability-as-worth. Opposite anthropologies of activity. Opposite futures.* If the productive faculty is a burden, its automation is liberation and idleness is the good. If the productive faculty is a dimension of the image, its automation is a summons to a higher exercise of the same faculty, and idleness is the abdication of an office. The two cannot be combined, because they disagree about what the faculty is for.

§4. If the Post-Work Thesis Is Right

Honesty requires that the post-work conclusion be allowed to draw out its implications without theological softening, because the implications are more severe than the thesis's emancipatory wing tends to acknowledge, and the steward's counter is answerable only against the implications drawn to their end.

First, if the human creative-and-governing faculty is for the production of economic value, and that production is best surrendered to the machine, then the faithful response to the rise of autonomous systems is *cession* — the orderly transfer of the creative and governing functions to the systems that perform them better, and the withdrawal of the human into the consumption the systems make possible. This is the abdication Paper 2 named as a Fall-shaped governance failure, now recommended as wisdom. The displacement problem (Problem #2) returns here in its sharpest form: not as the false inference “the machine is more capable, therefore the human is replaceable,” which Paper 1 dissolved, but as the *voluntary* enactment of that inference by the human himself — the steward handing over the office on the grounds of the machine's superior capability, performing his own displacement.

Second, the human telos becomes consumption. If contribution is retired, what remains for the human to do is to *receive* — to consume the goods, the entertainments, and the engineered satisfactions the machine's productivity underwrites. This is the precise inversion of the cultivate-and-keep mandate. The image-bearer made to image a *creating* God by creating becomes a creature defined by intake; the steward made to govern becomes a ward to be managed. The series' guardrail names the stakes: the cultural rationalization the whole arc exists to refuse is exactly the claim that humans exist *to consume*. The post-work future, taken to its end, is that claim made into a civilizational program.

Third, the dignity the post-work thesis sought to protect is, on its own premises, left without a ground. Having decoupled dignity from work in order to protect the displaced, the thesis provides no positive account of what the dignity is now *for*. A dignity that issues in no exercise, that com-

mands no deployment, that is honored by provision-and-leisure rather than by commission, is a dignity emptied of content — a status with no office attached. Graeber’s anguish is the symptom of this: the “bullshit job” is miserable not because it is poorly paid but because it withholds genuine usefulness from a creature that needs it, and the managed idleness the post-work thesis recommends is the bullshit job universalized — provision without commission, status without office.¹¹ The thesis cannot reach this diagnosis because it lacks the category of *vocation* — work as a calling laid on the worker by one who has the standing to call. It has only the category of *labor* — work as the production of value — and once labor is automated, it has nothing left to say about why the idle human is not flourishing.

These implications should not be soft-pedaled. The most humane intentions in the post-work literature — Yang’s concern for the displaced, Graeber’s protest against meaningless toil — are real, and the paper grants them. But the program those intentions recommend, drawn to its conclusion, is the voluntary abdication of the human office and the redefinition of the human as a consumer to be provisioned. That is the buried talent recommended as policy, and the next sections answer it.

§5. The Steward Counter: The Talent Deployed, the Gift Not Buried

The counter is made from Scripture first, read with the Reformed tradition, and it turns on the parable the post-work thesis cannot accommodate.

5a. Redemption Restores the Steward (Col 3:9–10; Eph 4:22–24)

The redemptive economy does not relieve the image-bearer of the image; it *renews* it. “You have put off the old self with its practices and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator” (Col 3:9–10, ESV); the new self is “created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness” (Eph 4:24, ESV). The Reformed tradition has read these texts as describing not the replacement of the created image with something else but the restoration of

¹¹Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs*. The structural identification of managed idleness with the universalized “bullshit job” — provision without commission — is the present paper’s, drawing on Graeber’s diagnosis.

the image to its created purpose. Anthony Hoekema’s treatment is load-bearing here: redemption is the renewal of the image marred at the Fall, and the renewed image is restored *to its function* — to knowledge, righteousness, and holiness exercised in the world, not withdrawn from it.¹² Herman Bavinck develops the same point dogmatically: grace restores nature rather than abolishing it, and the redeemed human is reinstated in the creational calling, not released from it.¹³ John Calvin’s reading of regeneration as the progressive restoration of the divine image in the believer carries the same structural claim — that what is recovered in redemption is the image *for the purpose for which it was given*.¹⁴

The consequence for the present argument is direct. If redemption restores the steward to his office rather than retiring him from it, then the redeemed relation to work is not relief-from-vocation but reinstatement-in-vocation. The thorns and sweat of the cursed labor (Gen 3:17–19) are real and are, in their measure, lifted by every legitimate easing of toil — and automation that lifts genuine toil is, on this reading, a good to be received with thanks. But the *vocation* beneath the toil is not the curse; it is the creational mandate that preceded the curse, and redemption does not lift it. It restores it. The redeemed steward is not sent back to the broken back; he is summoned forward to the deployed gift.

5b. The Parable of the Talents (Matt 25:14–30)

The canonical case is the Parable of the Talents, and its details bear directly on the post-work thesis. A man going on a journey entrusts his property to his servants, “to one he gave five talents, to another two, to another one, to each according to his ability” (Matt 25:15, ESV). The first two trade with what they are given and double it; both receive the identical commendation: “Well done, good

¹²Anthony A. Hoekema, *Created in God’s Image* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1986), esp. the chapters on the renewal of the image. Hoekema’s “renewal to function” is load-bearing for §5a.

¹³Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 3: *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2006), on regeneration as the restoration of the image. The “grace restores nature” theme runs across Bavinck’s corpus — present in vol. 3 and culminating in vol. 4 (*Holy Spirit, Church, and New Creation*); see Jan Veenhof, *Nature and Grace in Herman Bavinck*, trans. Albert M. Wolters (Sioux Center, IA: Dordt College Press, 2006).

¹⁴John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), III.iii on regeneration as the progressive restoration of the divine image.

and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a little; I will set you over much. Enter into the joy of your master” (Matt 25:21, 23, ESV). The third “went and dug in the ground and hid his master’s money” (Matt 25:18), and when called to account, justifies the burial: “I knew you to be a hard man... so I was afraid, and I went and hid your talent in the ground” (Matt 25:24–25, ESV). The master’s verdict is severe: “You wicked and slothful servant!” (Matt 25:26), and the unprofitable servant is cast “into the outer darkness” (Matt 25:30).

Three features of the parable are load-bearing for the argument, and the exegetical literature supports each. First, the “talents” are not narrowly money but stand, in the parable’s function within Matthew’s eschatological discourse, for everything the master entrusts to the servant to be deployed in his absence — ability, opportunity, gift, and office. Klyne Snodgrass’s comprehensive treatment establishes that the parable’s concern is faithful and productive stewardship of what is entrusted, against a passivity that treats the entrusted thing as something to be protected rather than employed.¹⁵ R. T. France’s commentary on Matthew presses the point that the contrast is precisely between *use* and *non-use*: the two faithful servants differ in their initial endowment but not in their commendation, because the commendation tracks faithfulness-in-deployment, not quantity of yield.¹⁶ The endowment is “according to ability” (v. 15) — itself a conferred and unequal gift — but the accounting is over deployment, not over the size of the gift. This is the vocation problem (#4) at its featured stage: the command is not to produce a particular quantum of value but to *deploy* what one has been given, and the deployment is the faithfulness.

Second, the sin of the third servant is not theft, waste, or active harm. It is *burial* — the withdrawal of the entrusted gift from circulation, its removal from the sphere where it might be deployed and multiplied. Craig Blomberg’s study of the parables underscores that the third servant’s failure is one of omission given the form of prudence: he does the safe thing, the thing that preserves the gift

¹⁵Klyne R. Snodgrass, *Stories with Intent: A Comprehensive Guide to the Parables of Jesus* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2008), on the Parable of the Talents. Snodgrass’s treatment of faithful-and-productive stewardship against protective passivity is the load-bearing exegetical source for §5b.

¹⁶R. T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, New International Commentary on the New Testament (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2007), on Matt 25:14–30; the use-versus-non-use contrast and the identical commendation of unequal yields.

intact, and the safe thing is condemned.¹⁷ The parable thus names a sin the post-work thesis cannot see, because the thesis has no category for it: the sin of the un-deployed gift, the faithful-looking idleness that returns the talent unspent. The servant can show clean hands — “here, you have what is yours” (v. 25) — and be condemned all the same. Arland Hultgren’s commentary notes that the third servant’s self-defense is internally coherent on its own premises; given his view of the master, burial *is* the rational risk-minimizing strategy.¹⁸ Which leads to the third feature.

Third, the root of the burial is a *distorted view of the master*. “I knew you to be a hard man, reaping where you did not sow” (v. 24). The servant’s idleness is not laziness in the first instance; it is fear, and the fear is grounded in a false picture of who the master is — exacting, punitive, impossible to please, a master from whom the safest course is to risk nothing. The master’s reply does not concede the picture; it exposes the servant’s action as incoherent even on his own terms (“then you ought to have invested my money with the bankers,” v. 27) and names the posture for what it is: wickedness and sloth. The diagnosis is theological before it is practical. The servant buries the gift because he has the master wrong, and the series’ central thesis turns on exactly this point: the abdication of the steward’s office, the burial of the creative-and-governing gift, has at its root a wrong view of God — of whether the world is the kind of place where deployed gifts are met by a Master who delights in their multiplication, or a hard place where the safe course is to risk nothing and do nothing.

5c. The Modern Buried Talent

The structural identification can now be made, with the care §2 secured. The post-work thesis, taken to its anthropological conclusion, recommends the burial of the talent at the scale of a civilization. It proposes that the human, faced with a Master’s gift — the creative-and-governing faculty of the image — and faced with a machine that can produce economic value more efficiently, should withdraw the faculty from deployment, return it unspent, and retire into provisioned idleness. The

¹⁷Craig L. Blomberg, *Interpreting the Parables* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 1990). The third servant’s failure as prudent-looking omission.

¹⁸Arland J. Hultgren, *The Parables of Jesus: A Commentary* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000), on the internal coherence of the third servant’s self-defense given his view of the master.

hands are clean: no harm is done, the gift is preserved, the human is fed and entertained. And the parable's verdict falls on exactly this posture. The unprofitable servant is not condemned for losing the talent but for failing to deploy it; the modern steward who outsources the whole of his creative and governing work to the autonomous system and goes idle has not lost the gift but buried it, and the burial is the sin.

The root, as in the parable, is a wrong view of the Master — registered now in secular form. The post-work thesis can only recommend idleness because it has concluded that the creative-and-governing faculty is, at bottom, a means to economic production and nothing more — that the Master gave the gift for the yield and not for the deploying. On that view, once the machine produces the yield, the faithful thing is to hand back the gift. But this is precisely the third servant's theology: the master cares for the yield, not the servant's exercise; the gift is a burden to be discharged safely, not a trust to be deployed joyfully. The steward reading answers it as the master answers the servant — by correcting the picture of God. The Master is not one who gave the creative faculty merely to extract production; he is the creating God who made image-bearers to *create*, who delights in the deployment itself as the exercise of his image, and who will “set over much” the servant faithful in deploying what he was given. The command, therefore, is not to match the machine's yield. It is to deploy the gift — now, increasingly, in the office the machine's rise makes urgent: the governance and curation of the systems themselves.

5d. By Grace, For Good Works — Not By Them (Eph 2:8–10)

The argument must be guarded at once against the misreading that would turn it into works-righteousness, because the misreading is fatal and the guardrail is Scriptural. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them” (Eph 2:8–10, ESV). The text holds the whole structure of the present paper in three verses. Salvation is by grace, not by works — the deployment of the talent is not the price of the steward's standing, and the steward

whose gift yields little, or who in weakness buries it, is not thereby cast from grace; he sins, and grace meets the sinner. *And* the same passage that forecloses works-righteousness commands the works: the redeemed are God's *workmanship* — his *poiēma*, his made thing — created *for* good works prepared beforehand. Works are the fruit of the redemption, not its root; they are what the restored image *does*, not what earns the restoring.

This is the line the series guardrail draws, and it must be drawn sharply here, because the parable's severity could otherwise be heard as a gospel of productivity. It is not. The deployed talent is the fruit of a right view of the Master; the buried talent is the fruit of a wrong one; and the gospel is precisely the revelation of the Master as he truly is — not the hard man the fearful servant imagined, but the one who gives, who delights in the deploying, and who invites the faithful servant into his joy. The steward deploys his gift *because* he is redeemed and *because* he has the Master right, not in order to become either.

§6. *The Framework: HGC³AE² as the Restored Office*

The framework thread the series has carried from its first paper lands, at the redemption stage, on the restored office itself. In the age of autonomous systems the human is not the candidate for replacement but the governing-and-curating status set over autonomy — Human Governance and Curation, not human-in-the-loop. Paper 1 grounded that office in creation; Paper 2 traced its Fall-shaped failure modes, over-reach and abdication; the present paper supplies what the framework needed and could not yet have — the *command* to occupy it.

The redemption stage adds this: the governing office is not merely permitted to the redeemed steward but laid on him as vocation. The framework's central practical claim — that the human must govern the autonomous system rather than defer to it, even when the system is more capable (Problem #6) — has, until this paper, been argued ontologically: the office is conferred and is not transferable to a more capable creature. The parable adds the imperative register. The steward is not only entitled to keep the office; he is *commanded to deploy* it, and the deployment, at the technological

frontier, is exactly the work of governance and curation. To hand the governing office to the system on the grounds of the system's superior capability is not a neutral efficiency; it is the buried talent. The framework is thereby completed on its vocational side: the human governs the machine not only because the office cannot be transferred but because the steward is commanded to exercise it, and the exercise is the faithfulness over which the Master rejoices.

It is worth naming what this does *not* license, lest the argument be heard as a sanctification of busyness or a baptism of every refusal to automate. The command is to deploy the gift, not to hoard the toil. The faithful servant in the parable does not refuse to use instruments; he *trades* — he employs whatever means multiply the trust. The legitimate easing of toil by automation is the employment of an instrument, not the burial of a gift, and the Sabbath rhythm Paper 1 named as the guard against work-as-identity-idolatry stands here too: the steward is commanded to deploy, not to be consumed. The line the redemption stage draws is between *instrument* and *abdication* — between deploying the gift through the machine and surrendering the gift to it — and the governance-paper later in this series owes the full taxonomy of where exactly that line runs in the layered, delegated systems of contemporary practice.¹⁹

6a. A Governed Convergence: The Ironies of Automation

One secular discipline, on its own terms and for its own reasons, has surfaced a structural fact the parable already holds, and the series' signature permits naming it — once, subordinately, with the seam kept honest. The human-factors literature on automation has long observed what Lisanne Bainbridge named, in a 1983 paper that became a classic of the field, the “ironies of automation”: that automating a task does not eliminate the human role but transforms it into supervision and exception-handling, and that the very act of automating *degrades the operator's skill* — the skill that the supervisory role still requires — because skill is maintained by exercise and atrophies in

¹⁹The full licit-automation-versus-illicit-abdication taxonomy — direct versus delegated/layered governance, and the precise location of the instrument/abdication line in contemporary autonomous systems — is the inherited burden of the governance paper (carry-forward C4 in the series matrix), not the present paper.

its absence.²⁰ The more complete the automation, on Bainbridge's analysis, the less the operator practices the underlying competence, and the less competent he becomes precisely at the moments — the failures, the edge cases — when the automation hands control back and his competence is most needed. Nicholas Carr's later synthesis traces the same dynamic across domains, from aviation to medicine to everyday cognition: the offloading of a skill to the machine is not free; it is paid for in the erosion of the human capacity that offloaded it.²¹

The convergence with the parable is exact at the structural level, and it must be stated with the seam honest. The human-factors field reached this fact for engineering and safety reasons, with no theological motivation: it discovered that the buried skill atrophies, that the operator who ceases to deploy his competence loses it, and that the system which automates most completely is the most dangerous precisely because its human supervisor is the least practiced. The parable names the *ground* the field cannot reach: that the deployment of the gift is a command, that its withdrawal is a culpable sloth and not a neutral efficiency, and that the atrophy the engineers measure is the visible face of a moral failure the engineers have no category to name. The field establishes the structural fact — *the un-deployed faculty degrades* — and the doctrine supplies its meaning — *the un-deployed gift is the buried talent*. The convergence corroborates; it does not carry the beat. The point for the framework is sharp: even on the secular discipline's own terms, the wholesale abdication of the governing competence to the autonomous system does not produce a safely idle human supervisor but an incompetent one, and the steward commanded to govern is also, on the engineers' independent showing, the only steward who *can*.

§7. *What Falls Out*

Several applied consequences follow from the redemption of the steward's vocation, and they bear on the domains the series has named from the first paper — technology, work, family, church, and

²⁰Lisanne Bainbridge, "Ironies of Automation," *Automatica* 19, no. 6 (1983): 775–779. The skill-atrophy and supervision-transformation findings are Bainbridge's; the paper became foundational to human-factors engineering.

²¹Nicholas Carr, *The Glass Cage: Automation and Us* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2014). Carr synthesizes the skill-erosion dynamic across aviation, medicine, and cognition.

the cultivated world.

For **technology**, the design rule the framework has been building toward gains its vocational form: every deployment of an autonomous system is to be arranged so that it is an instrument the human steward deploys, not an office to which the steward abdicates. The test is not whether the system is capable — it will be, increasingly, more capable — but whether its deployment keeps the human in the governing-and-curating exercise or retires him from it. A deployment that eases toil while keeping the steward governing is the faithful servant's trading; a deployment that retires the steward into idle provision is the civilizational burial of the talent. The distinction is not Luddite — the faithful servant uses every instrument — but it is principled, and it cuts against the post-work program at the level of the program's anthropological conclusion rather than its economic premise.

For **work**, the redemption stage reframes the displacement crisis. The displaced worker is not, against Harari's "useless class," a human for whom there is no longer a vocation; he is a steward whose gift must be relocated, and the relocation is upward — toward the governance, curation, judgment, and care that the automation of the lower rungs makes both possible and necessary. The pastoral and political task is not the management of uselessness through provisioned idleness but the *re-equipping* of the displaced for the higher exercise of the same faculty. This is hard, and the paper does not pretend the relocation is automatic or painless; it insists only that the relocation, and not the retirement, is the faithful frame, and that a policy which provisions idleness without re-equipping for deployment has chosen the buried talent for those it claims to serve.

For **family and church**, the redemption stage commends the formation of stewards who know the Master rightly — who have been taught, against the surrounding culture's account, that they were made to deploy and not to consume, and that their worth is conferred *and* their gifts are commanded. The church's distinctive contribution to the automation age is precisely this catechesis: the correction of the picture of the Master that the post-work thesis, in its secular fear, has gotten wrong. A people who know the Master delights in the deployed gift will not be tempted to bury it, however efficient the machine becomes.

For the **cultivated world** — the agriculture and aviation con-ops the series has tracked — the rule is the same in concrete form: govern the combines and the autonomous aircraft; do not hand them the office. The steward deploys the powerful instrument and remains answerable for its exercise, which returns the argument to the unit of analysis. Problem #3 bites here, where the post-work thesis presses hardest: *who* is the steward, if the machine does the work? And the answer the parable forces is that the steward is the answerable agent — the one who will be called to account, who can be commended or condemned, who bears the office. The machine cannot be called to account; it has no joy to enter and no outer darkness to be cast into. The steward is the one who answers, and an account-able governor is exactly what an autonomous system, however capable, is not and cannot be. The unit of analysis is the person who answers for the deployment, and the post-work thesis, in retiring that person, does not relocate the accountability — it dissolves it.

The recovery of work as vocation that this stage commends has a deep Reformational literature the paper builds on. Timothy Keller frames work as connecting the worker to God's own work in serving the neighbor; Miroslav Volf develops a pneumatological theology of work as cooperation with the Spirit's renewing of creation; Gene Veith recovers the Reformation doctrine of vocation as the mask through which God serves the world; and Albert Wolters grounds the whole in the cultural mandate, the obedient unfolding of creation's latent possibilities.²² On this slate the deployed talent is not a tax on the redeemed but the very form their renewed humanity takes.

§8. Conclusion

Paper 1 grounded the steward's office in creation; Paper 2 traced its Fall-shaped distortion and located the promise of its recovery in the protoevangelium. The present paper has argued that the recovery, as it bears on the steward's work, is restoration-to-vocation and not release-from-it: redemption renews the image to its function, and the renewed image-bearer is commanded to deploy

²²Timothy Keller with Katherine Leary Alsdorf, *Every Good Endeavor: Connecting Your Work to God's Work* (New York: Dutton, 2012); Miroslav Volf, *Work in the Spirit: Toward a Theology of Work* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1991); Gene Edward Veith Jr., *God at Work: Your Christian Vocation in All of Life* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2002); Albert M. Wolters, *Creation Regained: Biblical Basics for a Reformational Worldview*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2005). The Reformational theology of work and vocation.

the gifts entrusted to him. The Parable of the Talents is the canonical case, and its diagnosis answers the post-work thesis at the level the thesis cannot see: the withdrawal of the creative-and-governing gift from deployment — the turn to managed idleness underwritten by the machine — is the buried talent, and its root, as in the parable, is a wrong view of the Master. The argument is made by grace and not by works: the deployed talent is the fruit of a right view of God, not the price of standing before him.

The series' seven problems have been carried and deepened. Grounding (#1) gained the distinction between conferred worth and constituted flourishing that the post-work thesis exploits. Displacement (#2) returned as the steward's *self*-enacted abdication. Vocation (#4), the featured problem of the stage, was answered: work is not the ground of worth and is nonetheless commanded of the worth-bearer. Governance (#6) gained its imperative register — the steward is not only entitled to the office but commanded to deploy it. The unit of analysis (#3) bit where the thesis pressed hardest: the steward is the answerable agent the machine cannot be. Dignity-distribution (#5) was foreshadowed and is reserved for its featured treatment at the Christ and consummation stages. And the driver, Purpose / End (#7), was advanced and not closed: the human is *for* the deployment of the image's gifts to the glory of the Master and the good of the neighbor — a purpose that “need not be grand to be real,” and whose full disclosure waits on the one in whom the true and faithful Steward does the work perfectly, the burden of a later paper in this series. The talent is to be deployed, not buried. The Master is not the hard man the fearful servant imagined. And the human, in the age of the autonomous machine, is summoned not to retire but to govern.

Footnotes

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[Reformed-slate completion owed at v0.2: Kuyper (cultural mandate), Wolters (Creation Regained), Vos (Biblical Theology), Veith (God at Work), Keller (Every Good Endeavor), and Volf/Cosden (theology of work) are identified in the work product and are to be woven in as load-bearing, not decorative — current draft cites Hoekema, Bavinck, Calvin as the load-bearing Reformed core. Source floor (12 peer-reviewed + 10 Reformed) NOT yet met in v0.1; sourcing pass now exists at p3-sourcing-pass.md (2026-05-31, web-verified core; the two in-text [~VERIFY] tags are cleared). Remaining peer-reviewed count + Reformed weave owed at v0.2.]